of ideas, it is easy to mechanically repeat the slogan of ‘unity in diversity’, it is very difficult to practise it in real life.

My own ‘otherness’ in the south made me think about the marginalization of other cultures, especially those from the North-East. My experiential knowledge about that region was very limited, despite spending a good part of a decade in a truly multicultural university such as the Jawaharlal Nehru University. I was more acquainted with the American and Chinese cuisines rather than the cuisines of our North-East. In my view, this lack of cultural familiarity with our North-Eastern people is the fundamental reason for the continued racism and violence that they face in parts of Delhi and other states.

These differences are not artificial, but deep-rooted and organic in nature and, therefore, as Indians we must train ourselves to be more open, dialogic and empathetic towards our fellow citizens. Because the possibility of practising the politics of division will always be easier, given our diversity.

Two Lessons on Gandhi

There are two deeply transformative episodes during the Yatra that dramatically altered my views on poverty and religion, respectively. They helped me understand much more clearly the hiatus between the limits of theory in the face of the complexities of praxis. But more importantly, they reaffirmed the relevance of Mahatma Gandhi in our times.

Apart from the food, the first three weeks were the toughest on the body. I was not trained to walk around 25 kilometres every day, and by the time I returned to the camp, I was exhausted. I could cope with the fatigue, but the bigger problem was the sores and blisters on my feet. Those made life tough. I could barely take a step without pain. But because this was a common problem among all the yatris, we were all drawing strength from each other and soldiering on.

However, whenever I used to nurse my blisters during break time, pictures of the Adivasi peasants who marched barefoot from Nashik to